of "communal" and "casteist" parties in UP are having "sleepless nights" as she has given "proper representation" to Muslims in the urban local body polls. In her statement, she also appealed to voters to pay more attention to their "own interests" and be wary of "conspiracies" being hatched by her opponents. "The BSP is an Ambedkarite party," she added, "which follows the principles of *sarvajan hitay* and *sarvajan sukhay* (everyone's welfare and happiness)."

Mayawati's gambit has set the alarm bells ringing in the SP camp. "We were miles ahead of the BSP in the assembly elections last year," says a senior SP leader, on the condition of anonymity, "but the kind of ticket distribution they [BSP] have done for the civic body polls could hamper our chances in minority-dominated seats." The BSP has fielded Muslim mayoral candidates in Mathura, Saharanpur, Prayagraj, Moradabad, Meerut, Shahjahanpur, Bareilly, Aligarh and Ghaziabad besides Lucknow, which is reserved for women, and Firozabad, which is reserved for OBC women. Eight of these cities are in western UP, where Muslims are in excess of 25 per cent of the population.

MAYAWATI'S MUSLIM OUTREACH HAS SET THE ALARM BELLS RINGING IN THE SP CAMP THAT COUNTS ON THE MINORITY VOTE

Thus, any tilt towards the BSP—in a triangular fight that also has the ruling BJP in the running—could spell trouble for the SP by cutting into its Muslim votes, notes Dr Shilp Shikha Singh, a Lucknow-based political analyst. "The BSP is playing the role of the BJP's B-team," alleges the SP leader quoted earlier. "The bigger challenge for us is to convey this message to the minorities, so they don't waste their ballot on the BSP." As for Mayawati, the challenge is to make a success of her new Dalit-Muslim unity pitch in the three-tier municipal polls, considered to be the semifinals ahead the 2024 parliamentary elections. ■

SAURASHTRA TAMILS

FROM SALEM TO SOMNATH

By Jumana Shah

A millennium-old connection was revived recently when Saurashtra Tamils visited the old homeland they had migrated from centuries ago, and took in its wonders. Kicked off in mid-April by defence minister Rajnath Singh in the temple town of Somnath, some 5,000 visitors, who still hold on to their customs and even speak a version of Gujarati called Saurashtri, visited the state as part of the Saurashtra-Tamil Sangamam, a quasi-political programme organised by the Gujarat government, between April 17-27.

The genesis of the '*sangamam*' event is an important slice of forgotten history. Between 1000 and 1024 AD, Turkish invader Mahmud of Ghazni plundered the temple town Somnath 17 times. To escape the violence, several local communities migrated from Prabhas-Patan in the coastal peninsula of Saurashtra, which comprises 13 districts. These communities, mainly from the silk-weaving communities, travelled south from Surat to Devagiri in present-day Daulatabad in Maharashtra which was then under the Yadava kings. They lived there for two centuries, but had to move again after another invader, Alauddin Khilji, laid waste to that northern Deccan kingdom in 1296. They next moved to the Vijayanagara empire in the south. On the invitation of the Nayak rulers (1529-1736), some members of the community moved further south to Madurai in modern-day Tamil Nadu. Some families also settled in Salem, Tanjore and Paramakkudi. In Karnataka, they first settled in Srirangapattinam on the invitation of Mysore's ruler Hyder Ali. These families are now settled in Bengaluru. In Andhra Pradesh, a section of the community is settled in Tirupati and have possibly spread to neighbouring towns and cities. Because they were involved in the business of weaving silk, making garments and the silk trade, they were largely engaged with the royal kingdoms of the time. After



WELCOME Saurashtrian Tamil guests dance with local artists at Veraval rail station, Gir Somnath district, Apr. 17